

What the heck does (this) engineering manager do?

An honest, mildly chaotic, and occasionally sarcastic accounting of my job
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Nobody really
knows what an EM
does

So...

Let's break it down

Skill #0: Making rough guesstimates

- People 45%
- Delivery 30%
- Strategy 10%
- Ops & surprises 15%

“part diplomat, part therapist, part incident firefighter, and part calendar Tetris champion”

– GPT-5 mini, Feb 2026

Skill #1: People -> cultivate psychological safety and terrible dad jokes in equal measure

Listen well

- in 1-1s learn about you and use any info you give me in the most unexpected time - the single best lever ;)

Mentoring and coaching

- mentor future leaders and occasionally promote my own favorite puns
- delegation of stakeholder mgmt and writing design docs

“be the buffer between upper management and the engineers”

– anonymous

Skill #2: Delivery ->
translate “*we need
more time*” into “*let’s
deliver the smallest
valuable thing.*”

Get the ball rolling

- strategically nudge the conveyor belt, aka “sprinting”
- make trade-offs and then blame them on reality

Engineering excellence

- argue for tests and then quietly grieve when someone merges with no CI

Note to self: don't stop people coding — make sure what they ship doesn't explode in front of customers

Skill #3: Strategy ->
turn ambiguous
roadmaps into
mildly plausible
release dates

Thank god it's only 10%

- shepherd design docs into being and occasionally into production
- delegation of stakeholder mgmt
- pre-mortems

Skill #5: Ops & surprises -> attend meetings so you don't have to invent reasons we missed the deadline

Stakeholders and expectations

- own the problem, calm the room, and take the blame with style
- keep CI from crying and our product managers from hyperventilating
- fight CVEs by day and existential dread by night

The end goal

- manage the chaos so engineers can manage the code

"If you need someone to own the problem, calm the room, and take the blame with style — that's me."

The many paths to becoming an engineering manager

Work on these:

- Practice 1-1s
- lead a project
- write design docs
- do interviews
- get a mentor

Be on the wrong place at the wrong time:

- lead a team at the time when your manager is leaving

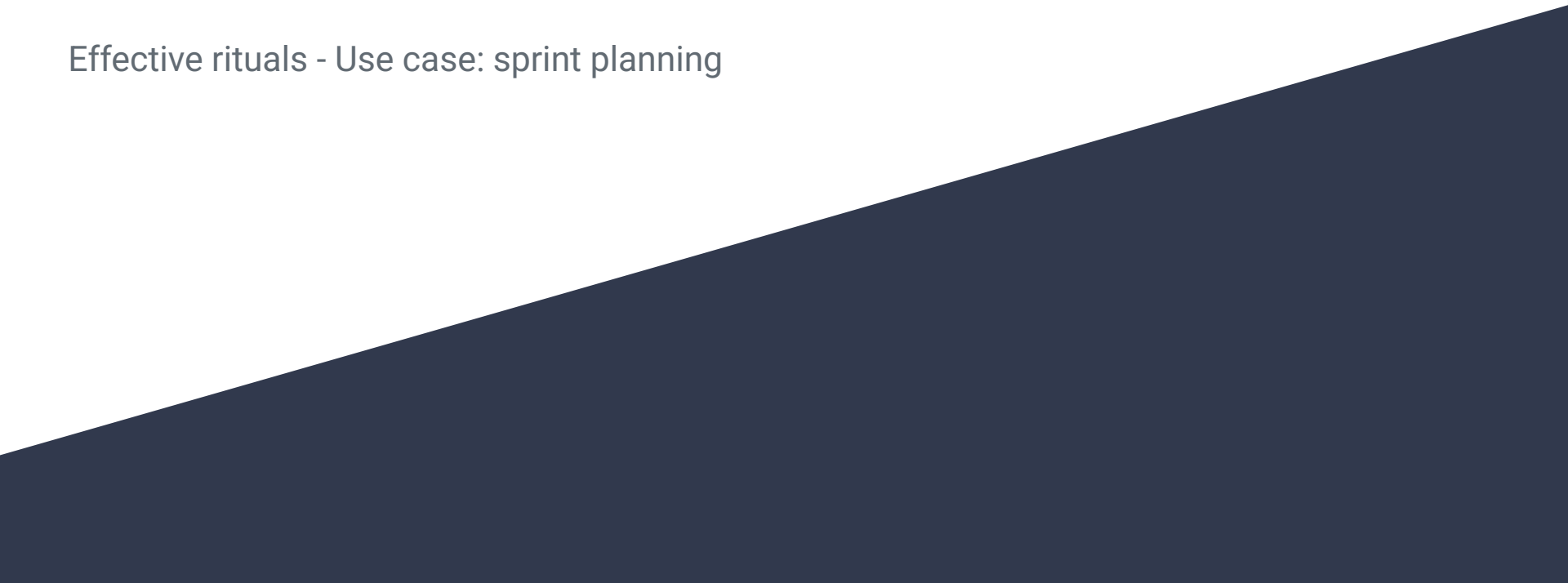
....or just:

- apply for the job

- CEO: See what you can do with these biological LLMs.
- Lead: What do you mean?
- CEO: Congrats on your promotion

Engineering manager: seriously now

Effective rituals - Use case: sprint planning

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What is a sprint?

Epic: a large chunk of work, the goal

Task: small chunk of work that is part of an epic

Task size: time/effort a task will take to complete

Sprint: a time-boxed period where a team works to complete a set amount of work

Sprint planning: the process of deciding what work needs to be done in a sprint

Sprint planning meeting: event that starts a sprint

Sprint planning timeline:

1. Pre-planning period
2. Planning
3. Sprint planning meeting (commit)
4. Execution

Running a sprint is easy, right?

- 1. Run biweekly sprints.
- 2. Size tasks based on the estimated time required to complete them.
- 3. Ensure tasks included in the sprint are no larger than three days of work.

A few days before sprint planning meeting

- 1. Provide the team with overall guidelines and update them on current priorities.
- 2. Invite team members to propose tasks they want to work on.
- 3. The manager assigns specific tasks to each team member.

The work no one sees

- Reviewing team member proposals
- Review current state of ongoing epics
 - reading docs,
 - reviewing code/PRs,
 - have 1-1 conversations
- Shift priorities or start a new epic
- Estimating carry over tasks from the previous sprint
- Prioritizing the entire pool of possible tasks
 - member suggestions,
 - carryovers, and
 - new items
- Assigning tasks based on
 - individual availability,
 - alignment with priorities,
 - timezone constraints,
 - collaboration opportunities, and
 - personal growth goals.

Repeat...

During the sprint planning meeting

- 1. Review the priorities with the team.
- 2. Discuss tasks to be carried over from the previous sprint.
- 3. Go through the selected tasks for each team member to ensure they are well understood.

Not just distributing task, you're making decisions

- A teammate having a difficult time (personal loss, divorce, war).
 - More work or less?
- High-priority item to a senior or junior?
 - Deadline vs growth
- Do you cluster tasks around timezones?
 - Cross team collaboration
- Is anyone about to quit?
 - Distribute knowhow
- Burnouts

At a high level

A set of policies and processes that:

- Allow the team to move forward
- Places the EM in a position to specify the direction

The real KPI: fewer
panic meetings,
more celebratory
snacks

Thank you!

